

Sibling conflict

Conflict usually occurs when people are frustrated or feel that they are not being heard. Each family has a unique dynamic, but here are some common problems.

Rivalry

Sharing parents with a sibling can be hard for a teen. They might feel their sibling gets more attention, and that they need to compete with them. Parents need to be alert to any perceived inequalities.



Favoritism

Sometimes, a teen may feel excluded or as if the parent prefers their sibling. This favoritism can be real without the parent realizing. To ward off perceived bias, parents need to ensure no one is left feeling excluded.



Problem behavior

Setting firm family rules will help parents and siblings alike to know what is acceptable. When a teen breaks the rules, parents should try to understand the feelings underlying the behavior.



Interfering

At a time when teens want more privacy, invasion into their personal space and belongings can cause disagreements. Parents can help by setting clear rules about space and privacy.



Blended families

A blended family is when two adults bring together their children from previous relationships into the same home. Households can be thrown into disarray while everyone makes space for the new arrivals and reassesses their place in the family dynamic.

A family unit of step-parent, biological parent, step-siblings, and half-siblings can be tricky for everyone to navigate and feel at home with. Small steps and allowing time for everyone to adjust are the keys to household harmony.

▷ Being friends, too

Seeing step-siblings as friends can help to resolve conflicts. Enjoying this friendship can be rewarding.



PARENT TIPS

Expanding families

- Try to do things together as a new family, giving everybody a chance to choose activities that everyone can enjoy.
- In a blended family, have one-on-one time with your biological children. Keeping that bond strong is important for children to accept the changes—they can often feel a huge loss of a parent as the relationship dynamics inevitably change.
- Be clear about who disciplines who in the step-family. Too much change can cause confusion and possibly anger.